In the meantime, Jewish organizations are asking the State Department to cancel Smotrich's visa to the US.

A record number of demonstrators. In Tel Aviv, there are about 160,000, and across the country, an estimated 250,000. It is the ninth week of demonstrations. Israel has never seen such mass popular mobilization for such an extended period.

Eli Ben-Elissar was one of my friends during my student years in Paris. We studied at Sciences Po and worked together at the Israeli Embassy. This was in the 1950s. I was not aware of the fact that he was a member of Herut and close to Begin. In the late 1970s, after Begin's electoral victory and Sadat's historic visit, Eli participated in the Cairo negotiations. He later became chairman of the Foreign Affairs and Defense Committee of the Knesset, then ambassador to France. He died during his stay in Paris. I am telling all of this because we met quite often at my house in Jerusalem when Eli had to be in town for Knesset meetings. By then I had moved to the left and was a member of Meretz (at some stage, the party chairperson, Shulamit Aloni, asked me to be the person closing the list), so that Eli and I did not see eye-to-eye regarding the main political issues, particularly the occupied West Bank. Eli's—and his party's—position was that Israelis and Palestinians could live and interact peacefully in an Israeli-controlled West Bank, notwithstanding the settlements. Israeli control was necessary for security reasons.

It may be that some of Begin's acolytes believed this, but the argument became increasingly threadbare as the years went by, and my meetings with Eli tailed off. The trouble is that, as I have already mentioned, the settlements started immediately after the Six-Day War under Mapai (socialist) governments; that socialist prime ministers did not believe in the reality of a Palestinian nation (remember my meeting with Golda Meir?); and that the present situation has deep historical roots. In short, I dare say